This Artist Turns Pumpkins into Spooky Sculptures

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Looking for Halloween pumpkin ideas? Artist Ray Villafane does not just carve pumpkins. He turns them into detailed **3-D sculptures**, usually with spooky faces.

Villafane was born in Queens, New York, and grew up on Long Island. After art school, he moved to Michigan and became an art teacher. One Halloween, he sculpted a pumpkin that impressed his students so much that they asked him to make more. Soon, local hotels and restaurants wanted his pumpkins too.

"I really enjoyed what I had stumbled upon," Villafane says.

His skills led to jobs making toys. In 2006, he started part-time at Marvel Comics, where his wax sculpture of Wolverine from X-Men was turned into a real product. He later worked full-time at DC Comics. But pumpkins remained his true love, and in 2010 he left to carve them full-time. He has also won Food Network's Outrageous Pumpkins competition twice and makes **sculptures** from sand, sticks and wood.

One of his **permanent** works is the "Boneyard Mining Company" at Vulture City Ghost Town in Arizona. It tells the story of two creatures: Gordy, who dreams big, and Grimgor, who doubts everything. Villafane says they represent the **optimist** and **pessimist** inside all of us.

This Halloween, Villafane's work is on display at the Great Gilbert Gourd Hunt in Gilbert, Arizona, through November 1, 2026. It features more than 40 pumpkin characters set up in scenes around the town. On October 24, visitors can watch him carve a pumpkin live.

His top tip? Pick a big, heavy pumpkin with plenty to carve, and don't worry if it isn't perfectly round. Odd shapes add character.

Word Treasure

sculptures -- Sculptures are works of art made by carving, shaping or building materials into 3-D forms.

3-D -- 3-D means three-dimensional, having height, width and depth instead of being flat.

optimist -- An optimist is a person who expects good things to happen.

pessimist -- A pessimist is a person who expects things to go badly.

permanent -- Permanent means meant to last for a long time without being taken away.

Background you need

Carving pumpkins into jack-o'-lanterns is a popular Halloween tradition in the United States.

Most people cut simple shapes through a pumpkin's shell, but sculptors like Villafane carve the thick flesh into detailed 3-D faces and figures.

Sculpting skills can carry over to other jobs, such as designing toys and action figures, as they did for Villafane.

Towns often hold fall displays where artists set up pumpkin scenes for visitors to explore.

Break it down

LEAD: Ray Villafane turns pumpkins into detailed 3-D sculptures
BACKSTORY: Art teacher in Michigan whose Halloween pumpkin amazed students
+- GROWTH: local hotels and restaurants wanted his pumpkins
CAREER: Toy sculpting at Marvel Comics (Wolverine) and DC Comics, then full-time pumpkin carving in 2010
OTHER WORK: Boneyard Mining Company at Vulture City Ghost Town, with Gordy and Grimgor
CURRENT EVENT: Great Gilbert Gourd Hunt in Gilbert, Arizona, through November 1, 2026; live carving October 24
TIP: Choose a big, heavy pumpkin; odd shapes add character

Why it matters

Villafane's story shows how a classroom hobby can grow into a career, and how art can bring a whole community together during a holiday.

Test what you remember

1. **What job did Villafane have before carving pumpkins full-time?**
   - (A) Art teacher
   - (B) Firefighter
   - (C) Farmer
   - (D) Chef
2. **Which X-Men character did he sculpt for Marvel Comics?**
   - (A) Cyclops
   - (B) Magneto
   - (C) Wolverine
   - (D) Storm
3. **In what year did he leave DC Comics to carve pumpkins full-time?**
   - (A) 2008
   - (B) 2026
   - (C) 2006
   - (D) 2010
4. **How many times has he won Food Network's Outrageous Pumpkins?**
   - (A) Once
   - (B) Never
   - (C) Twice
   - (D) Three times
5. **Where is his Halloween display this year?**
   - (A) Queens, New York
   - (B) Bellaire, Michigan
   - (C) Gilbert, Arizona
   - (D) Los Angeles, California
6. **What kind of pumpkin does Villafane recommend?**
   - (A) Small and perfectly round
   - (B) Very light and hollow
   - (C) Big and heavy, even if oddly shaped
   - (D) Painted white

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):